
The Home Decision Every Retirement Plan Forgets

Your advisor planned the 401(k). Nobody planned the house.

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RIGGINS STRATEGIC SOLUTIONS

“The biggest asset most families own is the one nobody made a plan for.”

A planning guide for families deciding what happens to the home, before a crisis decides it for them.

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The gap in every retirement plan

Your advisor has a plan for the 401(k), the pension and Social Security. Almost none of them have a plan for the house.

Sit down with a good financial planner and they will map your 401(k), your Social Security, your pension and your spending for the next thirty years. It is careful work and it matters. But look at what is usually missing from the picture: the house. For most families it is the single biggest asset they own, and it is the one nobody has a plan for.

That is not the planner's fault. Financial advisors do not touch real estate. Real estate agents mostly know one move, which is to list it. The senior care world does not do money. So the biggest asset in the plan falls in the crack between three professionals, and it stays there until a fall, a diagnosis or a stack of bills forces a decision.

Then it gets made fast, under pressure, by people who are exhausted. That is the most expensive way to make any decision, and right now it is the default.

You can make this call early instead, calmly, while nothing is forcing your hand. That is the entire purpose of this guide. Not to tell you what to do with the house, but to make sure you have seen the whole board before somebody else moves a piece of it for you.

WHAT THIS GUIDE IS NOT

This is education, not advice for your specific family, and it is not legal, tax or financial advice. Every family's numbers and health picture are different, and the tax points in particular are worth confirming with a CPA who can look at your actual return.

The five doors

There is never just sell or do not sell. There are five real doors, and the right one depends on health, money and what the family actually wants. Most families only ever hear about the first one, from the only professional who gets paid when they walk through it.

1. Sell now, cleanly

The simplest door, and often the right one, particularly while the tax treatment is still in your favor. The question is not who offers the highest number. It is what nets the most after the work, the fees, the carrying costs and the time. A lower offer with fewer repairs and a faster close can beat a higher one that needs thirty thousand dollars of work first.

2. Right-size

Sell the big house, buy or rent something smaller and safer, and put the difference to work. This is the door most people actually want and the one fewest plan for in time. It works best chosen early, because it depends on being well enough to move by choice rather than by ambulance.

3. Age in place

Stay, and modify the home for safety. This can absolutely be the right call. Run the real number first: the modifications themselves, the in-home care that usually follows, and the ongoing cost of a house that keeps asking for money. Those three add up faster than families expect, and they tend to arrive together.

4. Keep it and rent it

Turn the house into income. It can work. Run the honest net rather than the sticker rent: after management, taxes, insurance, a real repair reserve and vacancy, a rent check is a good deal smaller than it looks, and one aging roof can erase a year of it. Renting also starts a tax clock, which is the next section.

5. Creative and owner financing

For the right family, selling on terms can beat a cash sale, and there are legitimate cash options too. These are the advanced doors. They need somebody who knows all five well enough to say honestly whether one of them actually fits, rather than steering you to the one they happen to sell.

The five doors at a glance

A rough shape of each door. The numbers that matter are your own, and this is the grid to take to the professionals who can price them.

Door	Fits when	Watch for
Sell now	The house has to fund care, or the tax window is open and closing.	Net after repairs, fees and carrying cost, not the headline offer.
Right-size	Health is good enough to move by choice, and the house is too much.	Where the difference actually goes once it is freed up.
Age in place	Staying is the priority and the home can be made safe.	Modifications plus in-home care plus upkeep, added together.
Rent it	No need for the lump sum, and somebody will genuinely manage it.	Net after vacancy and reserves. It also starts a tax clock.
Terms or owner finance	Full price matters more than speed, and monthly income helps.	Needs an attorney who has actually drafted these before.

The two windows that close

Waiting has a price, and two pieces of it are hiding in the tax code. Neither is something you should have to know. That is exactly the point. They are worth real money, and they quietly reward the family that looked early.

The home sale exclusion

If the home has been the main residence for two of the last five years, a large share of the gain on a sale is likely to be excluded from tax. Rent the house out or wait long enough and that window winds down, so a sale that would have been nearly tax free starts being taxed.

The numbers and the edge cases genuinely matter here, and they turn on details specific to your family. Confirm them with a CPA. The direction of travel is the part worth carrying with you: this window closes with time, and it closes quietly.

The step up in basis

How the house is titled, and what happens at death, changes the tax picture dramatically for whoever inherits it. This is a titling and estate question rather than a will question, and a great many families discover far too late that those are two different things.

Confirm this one with a CPA and an estate attorney together, because the answer depends on how the deed actually reads today, not on what anyone remembers being decided years ago. Pull the deed and look. It is a twenty minute job and it is the single highest value twenty minutes in this guide.

THE TWENTY MINUTE VERSION

Find the deed and read exactly how the owners are named on it.

Write down when the home last served as the primary residence.

Take both to a CPA and ask what each of the five doors would cost in tax. You are not asking them to choose. You are asking them to price the options while all five are still open.

The one question

Does the house need to be the thing that pays for care, or is it the thing you want to protect and pass on?

Strip all of it away and the decision comes down to that. Income and savings answer it, and the answer points at the right door.

If the house has to fund care, then net proceeds and timing are everything, and doors one and two move to the front. If the house is meant to be protected and passed on, the titling and the step up matter more than the sale price, and the conversation changes shape entirely.

Families who ask that question early get to choose their door. Families who wait until a crisis get whichever door is closest, and it is usually the one with somebody standing in it holding a contract.

What to do with this

You do not need to decide today. You need to have looked at the whole board before somebody else forces a piece of it.

Pull the deed. Write down the dates. Ask a CPA to price the doors. Have the conversation with your family while it is still a conversation rather than a reaction.

IF YOU WANT A SECOND SET OF EYES

Ryan works with families on exactly this decision, from someone who has been on both sides of the table and makes nothing on whether your family sells or stays. He is a licensed North Carolina broker who never takes the listing himself.

Get Ryan in your corner: rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/work-with-ryan

Not ready to talk yet? The Family Readiness Score is a short self check, at no added cost: rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/tools/family-readiness-score